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What’s driving ‘teen takeovers’?

As young people seek activities, group connection, Chicago officials weigh public safety strategies

By **Caroline Kubzansky, Sam Charles and Jake Sheridan**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The 911 call came in just after 10:30 p.m. one recent Saturday night: Fifty teens in the street at 88th and Loomis, jumping on cars and damaging property.

Droves of Morgan Park (22nd) District police responded to the block, where dozens of young people were dancing, laughing, screaming and running back and forth.

Robert and Jasmine Williams sat

on the front stoop of their bungalow as police pushed the crowd north. One kid turned two backflips in a row in the middle of Bishop Street.

The pair had heard about “takeovers” in other neighborhoods, but had never actually encountered one in Auburn Gresham.

“It’s entertaining,” Robert Williams said. “We used to do this at Route 66, the skate rink.”

Such gatherings — known as “teen takeovers” or “teen trends” — have become increasingly common in Chicago over the last decade, especially during the warmer

months. They are sporadic, organized quickly on social media, and can sometimes end in violence or even fatal gunfire.

Mayors and police superintendents have for years struggled with how to appease wealthier, mostly white residents and tourists who may feel unsafe while ensuring the downtown area and lakefront are accessible to all residents, especially the city’s Black youths, who mostly live in poorer neighborhoods on the South and West sides.

As the takeovers have once again risen to the top of the city’s ongoing public safety discussion, Mayor Brandon Johnson has responded



Police disperse a group during a “teen takeover” in Chicago’s Auburn Gresham neighborhood on June 6. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/TRIBUNE**

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Storms brought dozens of tornadoes

Total of 44 for year is 3rd highest in area since records began in 1950

By **Adriana Pérez**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

At least 29 tornadoes ripped across Illinois and northwest Indiana last week, according to preliminary reports from the National Weather Service. As residents of parts of these states were recovering and surveying the damage from a destructive derecho that swept through Wednesday night with up to 80 mph winds, they were hit again less than 24 hours later with another round of severe thunderstorms and tornadoes.

A derecho is a widespread and long-lived thunderstorm with damaging winds.

As of the agency’s latest count Sunday, 17 of the confirmed tornadoes from last week occurred in northern Illinois and northwest Indiana, and nine in central Illinois. The Quad Cities weather service office confirmed three tornadoes in western Illinois of unknown intensity that caused no known damage.

The 17 tornadoes in northern Illinois and northwest Indiana brought the area’s tally for 2026 to 44 — already the third most of any year since recordkeeping began in 1950.

“This is well above average, already, for a typical year,” said Rafal Ogorek, a meteorologist with the weather service’s Chicago office.

The top two years with the most tornadoes in the office’s forecast area are 2024, with 63 confirmed tornadoes, and 2023, with 58. The entire state of Illinois typically averages 50 tornadoes annually.

Thursday produced three EF-3 tornadoes — which are characterized by speeds of 136 to 165 mph — that hit Streator, a city 81 miles southwest of Chicago; the village of Washburn near Peoria; and the towns of Hebron and Kouts in Porter County, Indiana.

No major injuries have been reported.

The EF or Enhanced Fujita scale goes from 0-5, with an EF-0 tornado starting at 65 mph and an EF-5 tornado being over 200 mph. Merrillville, in Indiana, was hit by an EF-2 tornado. This is the second time in three months a tornado of that velocity has swept through the area, after an EF-3 struck Lake Village in Newton County in March, killing an elderly couple in their home.

As human activities such as fossil-fuel burning release heat-trapping gases into the atmosphere and climate change inten-

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ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

STREETS OF DREAMS

Joabe Barbosa leads dozens of runners and supporters down Michigan Avenue from Oak Street Beach to Buckingham Fountain in Chicago on Sunday. Barbosa completed his mission of running every street in the city and finished with a crowd of people draped in Chicago flags cheering him on. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

A preventable bicycling tragedy on Halsted



A memorial for Riley O’Neil is on a bike rack in front of 3226 S. Halsted St. on June 7. O’Neil was struck and killed riding his bicycle there on June 5. **PETER TSAI/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

“I think that having a protected bike lane in this area is really important. I think that if there was one, this tragedy would have been avoided.”

TRAVIS CURTIS, a doctor who gave O’Neil CPR at the scene

Alderwoman says traffic safety is a ‘big balancing act’

By **Talia Soglin and Madeline Buckley**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

On a stretch of Halsted Street in Bridgeport, bicyclists and cars travel alongside each other, separated only by paint on the street.

There is no protective infrastructure like concrete blocks, or even plastic posts, and bicyclists often travel in a narrow strip of street between lines of parked cars and traffic.

It’s on that stretch of Halsted where city transportation planner Riley O’Neil died in a traffic crash on June 5.

O’Neil was biking south that Friday afternoon when someone opened a car door into his path, according to a witness and police source who spoke to the Tribune that day. O’Neil swerved

to avoid the door, but still made contact with it and was thrown to the street, sources said, where the driver of a semitruck ran him over.

Police issued citations to a man on the scene, but no one was taken into custody. Court documents reviewed by the Tribune show the man who allegedly opened the door into O’Neil’s path has a history of traffic infractions.

O’Neil died at 35.

Unlike the other cyclists and pedestrians killed in traffic crashes in Chicago this year, he was a city servant who devoted much of his career to bike safety and infrastructure. O’Neil worked as a planner and project manager at Chicago’s Transportation Department, where he was a member of the team devoted to making city streets safer and preventing traffic crashes.

In large part because of the

See **SAFETY** on Page A2

Trump: Iran peace deal reached

The United States and Iran reached a pact to end the war and open the Strait of Hormuz in a deal that mediator Pakistan said would be signed Friday. **Nation & World**

Summer Smash fights the elements

Largest independent hip hop festival in the Midwest gets a late start after days of severe weather, but opening day crowd sets record. **Arts & Living**

Sox win series against Dodgers

White Sox hit three home runs in the sixth inning as Chicago won for the second time in the three-game set against the defending champs. **Chicago Sports**

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